instillations and bridges over the next several days. As hostilities intensified, human rights violations on the part of government forces had become commonplace, according to Amnesty International and Asia Watch. A report released in December 2011 by Muse detailed atrocities committed during the 2010 to 2011 period. One of the most devastating parts of the escalation in fighting has been the number of civilians displaced throughout the region. This not only takes a toll on the population, but also hinders economic development.

Talks were held with the regime during the summer of 2010, but Kachin authorities wanted to ensure that any future political agreements regarding the ethnic question included all of the factions nationwide. This stipulation is unacceptable to the government, which has used a divide-and-conquer strategy very effectively throughout the past five decades. The Kachin leadership has requested Chinese assistance in ironing out the diplomatic issues, but thus far Beijing has refused to get directly involved.

The fighting between the government and KIO forces continued through 2010–2011. Since the Kachins believe that the Myanmar authorities reneged on earlier agreements, making a lasting agreement is problematic without guarantees being in place. As the cycle of violence continues, a durable solution becomes difficult. With the new administration of Thein Sein in place, the Kachin leadership will hopefully realize that the best opportunity for a long-term solution in recent decades may be possible.

A major step toward reconciliation was taken when the Myanmar authorities announced the suspension of work on the Chinese-built Myitsone dam project on September 30, 2011. The massive project was the largest of seven hydroelectric dams being constructed in the Kachin state. The Chinese government had signed on to the project in 2007 with construction starting in 2009. The project was being built by China Power Investment Corporation in partnership with the Asia World Company of Myanmar and the state-owned Myanmar Electric Power Enterprise. The dam (with a completion date of 2019) was to be the 15th-largest hydropower station in the world. The problem from the Kachin perspective was that nearly all of the electricity generated was to be exported to China's Yunnan province. Furthermore, several rivers would be flooded by the dam, which ultimately would destroy several historically and culturally important sites significant to the Kachin people. This in addition to the lack of benefits